

IN PROFILE

Emma Bardac

A talented singer in her own right, Bardac had close personal ties with two famous composers. She was Fauré's mistress in the 1890s, but later became Debussy's second wife. Emma's liaison with Fauré inspired two of his most delightful collections of piano pieces.

Fauré's song cycle *La Bonne Chanson*—with settings of poems by Paul Verlaine—was mainly written between 1892 and 1893, with Emma singing the songs back to him as he wrote them. More charming still was the *Dolly Suite*, which he produced for her daughter Régina (whose nickname was “Dolly”). One of its movements, *Berceuse* (Cradle Song), became famous in the UK as the theme for the BBC children's radio program *Listen with Mother*.



EMMA BARDAC, MISTRESS OF GABRIEL FAURE, 1903

Gabriel Fauré was born in southern France, in the foothills of the Pyrenees. He showed great musical promise and at the age of nine was sent to the *Ecole Niedermeyer* in Paris, where he